

DIEGO GAWENDA

Staff QA Software Engineer | AI-Augmented Quality Engineering Leader

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SUMMARY

Quality Engineering Leader with 15+ years driving test strategy, automation architecture, and team scaling across fintech and SaaS. Built QA teams of up to 12 engineers, cut regression time by 75%, and reduced production risk by 50% through shift-left practices and AI-augmented test design.

Built test automation frameworks from zero across two ecosystems — Playwright/TypeScript for web at Almanac, mobile automation at Flex — embedded CI/CD quality gates into engineering workflows, and defined production-readiness criteria and testing culture for growing engineering teams.

CORE SKILLS

Test Strategy • Test Architecture • Production-Readiness Criteria • CI/CD • GitHub Actions • Quality Gates
Shift-Left Testing • Risk-Based Testing • AI-Augmented Testing • Team Leadership • Team Scaling • Stakeholder Management • Quality Metrics
TypeScript • JavaScript • Java • Playwright • Cypress • Selenium • WebdriverIO • Detox • Maestro
API Testing • REST Assured • Postman • Contract Testing • SQL • Cucumber • Docker • Test Data Management • Performance Testing • Accessibility Testing (a11y)

EXPERIENCE

Staff SDET — Flex Feb 2024 – Present

Remote | US fintech startup, rent payment solutions

- Reduced regression testing time by 75% by designing and integrating a mobile automation suite into GitHub Actions, enabling daily release cycles instead of weekly.
- Increased release predictability by 80% by rebuilding the workload estimation process for the QA team, giving engineering leadership accurate delivery forecasts.
- Cut functional testing rework by 20% by introducing shift-left testing practices, catching defects during development instead of after handoff to QA.

Senior SDET — Almanac Jul 2022 – Dec 2023

Remote | US startup, async collaboration platform

- Improved team productivity by 50% by building an end-to-end automation framework in Playwright from scratch, replacing manual regression testing.
- Reduced defects reaching QA by 20% by embedding automated checks earlier in the development pipeline.

QA Lead / Senior SDET — dLocal Oct 2020 – Jul 2022

Montevideo, Uruguay | First Uruguayan fintech unicorn

- Increased automation ROI by 80% by implementing a daily monitoring process that identified and eliminated low-value flaky tests.
- Improved cross-team efficiency by 20% by leading knowledge-transfer sessions.
- Led and coached a QA team of 12 engineers, aligning automation strategy across multiple product squads.

QA Lead — The Appraisal Lane Jun 2016 – Aug 2020

Montevideo, Uruguay | US automotive marketplace startup

- Reduced production issues by 50% by designing and rolling out QA processes for a team built from zero to 10 engineers.
- Cut rework from 40% to 20% of completed tasks by defining clearer acceptance criteria and definition-of-done standards.
- Reduced regression testing time by 75% by leading the automation of core regression suites.

QA Manager / Senior QA Engineer — Greycon *Aug 2007 – Jun 2016*

Montevideo, Uruguay | UK manufacturing execution & planning software company

- Reduced development error rate by 40% by introducing root-cause analysis into the defect-resolution workflow.
- Managed a distributed QA team of 10 engineers across multiple countries, standardizing test processes globally.

EDUCATION

Software Engineering — Universidad de la República

Software Testing Leader — Centro de Ensayos de Software

LANGUAGES

Spanish (native) • English (professional working proficiency) • Portuguese • German